

The dead never bothered me. It was the living who made a mess. It's one of the reasons I chose this work. Above all things, I enjoy it. To the normal person, that sounds weird, but not to me. The music blasts through the speakers that I had installed when I took over this place more than four years ago. My assistant walks in with her noise-canceling headphones and her chocolate hair tied up in a bun on her head because she said she's sensitive to sound, when in reality, Tori just hates my music. Her hands fold over one another as she stands on the opposite side of the stainless steel table. She looks at the body, chest split open, as I begin to stitch it up, humming to the music, in my happy place.

My music suddenly goes quiet as she presses a button and removes her headphones.

"Time of death?" she asks, her face slightly pale. She hates coming in here, but I pay her well. And despite how much she detests it here, or even working the night shift, she does it without fail. I went through two employees before finally landing on Tori. She has a smart mouth, which I appreciate and need, considering who I work for. Not only is she efficient but most importantly, she's discreet.

"Two hours ago," I tell her, looking over my handiwork so far. "Give or take." I shrug. She swallows hard, her gaze sweeping over the body again of a man who looked to be in his mid-fifties. "Give or take," she repeats with a grim expression. I get it. For most people, looking down at a dead body is unsettling, but I'm the opposite. Each body that arrives in my morgue is like a new puzzle. "They're waiting for you," Tori says, visibly uncomfortable.

I sigh, annoyed that they're already encroaching on my fun.

Tying off the final suture and wiping my hands, I peel off the gloves. Officially, the man lying on my table choked on his own blood during a robbery gone wrong.

Unofficially, he was executed in the back seat of his car by someone who knew exactly where to aim.

After disposing of the gloves, I catch my reflection in the stainless steel bins as I walk out to where I know they're waiting. My long, deep-plum hair is pulled back in a braid so it stays out of my way, and my scrubs are black, which is fitting, really. Glancing away, I push open the door to find four men in the receiving room, all dressed in black, guns hidden beneath their tailored jackets—the Hayes crew, the third strongest family in the city. I watch as Cian slides an envelope across the counter in greeting.

"You did good work," he says with a smirk. Cian knows he's attractive, and every time he comes in, he looks at me a little too long with rich brown eyes that are anything but kind.

Most women probably melt under attention like that. Maybe that's why he does it, because he is used to people folding for him. But not me. His attention doesn't make me nervous. It irritates me more than anything. The arrogance of it. The way he acts like every look is calculated, every word designed to chip away at me until I finally crack open for him.

"I know." I don't need him to tell me I do good work. When I don't make a move to touch the money, he makes a point to lean his elbows on the counter so he is a little

closer to me. I don't back up. I stay exactly where I am. He always tries to unravel me, but it hasn't worked yet.

His eyes flutter to the money, and he looks back at me.

"You don't want it?" he asks.

Without a second thought, I open the drawer in front of me and slide the envelope inside without counting it.

He smirks. "You trust I gave you the right amount?" he asks as he pushes off the counter.

I don't like Cian. He's the kind of man who stares at himself in the window reflection a little too long. With his dark hair and custom suits, he looks like he should own the room when he walks in. But he doesn't.

I don't hide the contempt on my face.

Cian tips his head at me when I don't answer. One thing I know for certain about men like Cian is that they like the chase and the game, so I simply don't play. They'll get bored trying soon enough.

A smile twitches at his lips, but he has the better sense to leave with his men. I watch them as they walk through the door and wait to see the headlights on the car disappear before I walk into the back room where Tori's office is.

"They gone?" she asks, sitting on a metal stool, looking tired.

"Yes, and you should be too. Take off early. I can lock up. I'll see you tomorrow."

She doesn't have to be told twice, so she reaches for her purse and leaves.

Walking back into the autopsy room, I start to cover the body.

The sheet is halfway raised when something shifts, barely perceptible at first. Not a sound. Not a movement. Just the faintest change in the room, like the air has thickened without warning.

My hand stills, but I don't look up immediately. I wait, my head tilted, listening. The hum of the refrigeration unit. The distant drip of a tap that never quite shuts off properly. My own breathing, steady and controlled. I lower the sheet a fraction and let my eyes lift. The room feels colder now, though I can't tell if it's real or imagined. The hairs on my arms begin to rise, one by one, as if responding to some unseen force. Goosebumps spread across my skin.

Only then do I turn around.

A man is standing across the room from me, partially hidden by the shadows, his gaze trained on the body I am covering with the sheet.

It takes me a moment to recognize him.

Silas Vescari.

He's tall with broad shoulders and a solid build, the kind of frame that takes up space even when he isn't moving.

His hair is dark, short, and slightly uneven, not styled but not careless either.

When he steps into the light, I get a better look at his face. At the defined jaw, high cheekbones, and straight nose.

Everyone knows who he is and what he does. He's the head of the Vescari. The biggest crime syndicate in the state.

Not to mention the most ruthless man in the city.

What they don't tell you is how he seems to suck in the darkness of the room. How even with dim lighting, it's as if it avoids his space, and my instinct is to do the same.

His dark gaze sweeps around the room before it finally lands on me, as if I'm an afterthought that just stepped in. Instinct is great; it tells you when you should know better and when to run. Dealing with these types of men, however, you learn to ignore it and then some.

Annoyed at the intrusion, I cross my arms over my chest. I don't let anyone but Tori into my morgue. That's rule number one. I don't care who you are or who you work for; when I'm with a body, I work alone. But it's not just that I like to work alone. I also don't like anyone standing behind me.

I like to keep everything out of my blind spot.

His invasion of my space sparks the fire in my blood. Men like this think they own everyone and everything.

"You falsified a report," he says to me.

His voice is deep and smooth, and he holds himself with the confidence of a man who isn't afraid of anything or anyone.

I know men like him because I've been surrounded by them my entire life.

"I prefer to call it correcting a narrative," I say, refusing to be intimidated.

He takes a step forward, and in the fluorescent lights, I see his eyes are a deep blue, almost black, and they're ... *beautiful*.

Unlike Cian Hayes, this man doesn't perform power. *He is power*. And he knows it

"You knew who he was," he says, his gaze drifting to the body on the table. "Knew he was one of my men." His tone comes out more clipped, as if I was the one who put the bullet in him.

"Yes." There is no point in lying. The Vescari crew all have a brand on them. A tattoo announcing their allegiance to the family. This guy had it on his back. A raven mid-flight. There is no way I couldn't know he was a Vescari.

"Yet you did it anyway." He drags those deep sapphire eyes back to me.

I can see why people are afraid of this man, why they cower in fear in his presence. But I refuse to be afraid. And I sure as fuck don't cower.

*Not anymore.*

"It's my job," I say. I don't look away. I'm not going to show him any fear. "There was no conflict of interest. I don't work for you."

"No, you don't. You work for my enemies."

"No, I work for the dead."

He continues watching me in a very methodical way. The type of man I hate the most, because what's more dangerous than a man with pure muscle and bloodlust? One who actually has a brain.

Silas steps closer. He's wearing a suit jacket and a button-up shirt open at the collar. His chest and neck are covered in ink. Tattoos crawl out from his shirt cuff and travel along his hands to his fingertips.

I briefly glance at my scalpels, which are in reaching distance at the edge of the counter. He notices, but continues walking forward as he says, "By falsifying records?"

"By ensuring they don't end up in a shallow grave in the woods. It's because I do this that the dead get buried."

"You do this for money." He comes to a stop in front of me, pocketing his hands casually as if he's every bit a gentleman. He leaves enough distance for me to reach for the scalpel first if I need it.

"I do this so families get closure," I bite back.

He tilts his head, that cool intellect dancing in his gaze. "What about you? Do you get closure?"

Without thinking, I take a step back. *What does he mean by that?*

"I don't need closure."

His eyes flick to my name tag. A brief pause. Like he's registering the irony, but his expression doesn't change. One perfectly shaped eyebrow lifts. "You don't? Everybody is seeking some kind of closure, Miss Graves."

I don't like how closely this man looks, as if into my soul, and that has been off-limits for a very long time—even to me.

"It's *Dr.* Graves, and if you will excuse me, you need to leave. I'm locking up for the night."

His brows rise at the correction. He's not used to people correcting him. I cover the rest of the body and then pick up the clipboard at the end of the table to mark off some paperwork.

He stands at the edge of the table, a tic running through his jaw. "You know I'm going to avenge this man's death," he says in a voice that tells me the revenge will be bloody.

"That's not my concern," I say.

The man lying between us on my slab meant something to him. It's not only the tattoo that tells me he was family. It's the stillness in Silas's body as he looks down at him. In the tightening of his handsome facial features. The fists curling at his side.

And suddenly I'm five years old again, watching my father standing over my mother's coffin, his face drawn and his eyes tear stained...

"It was fast," I say, my voice cutting into the frigid air. "He wouldn't have known what hit him."

I don't know why I'm offering him an attempt at comfort. I never offer it. The men I work for don't pay me for comfort. They pay me to clean up a situation and keep my mouth shut. And they pay me really well. They sure as fuck don't walk into my workplace as if they own it.

I have never worked for the Vescari family. And I never will.

But his enemies come to me. That's why he's here. He knew this was where this man would be brought. *To me.* The one person the underworld trusts to ensure their narrative is the only one that makes it into official documents.

It's dangerous work. But I meant what I said. It's because I do this that they get buried and not dumped into a shallow grave where they'll never be found.

And truth be told, I really like money.

I guess that's what happens when you're raised by a parent who was constantly chasing it.

Silas turns, and his dark eyes lock on me again.

"If you cover up one of my men's deaths again, without my authority, you won't like the outcome."

Unblinking, I stare at him. He's probably delivered similar threats to many other people before. And I imagine they nodded their heads and assured him it would never happen again while praying he didn't shoot them on the spot.

But I am not easily unnerved. His threat does not scare me. It pisses me off. And it's been my experience not to piss people off when you want them to do something for you. I'm very much an *ask nicely* person. Anything less and I tend to get stabby.

"This is business, Mr. Vescari. It's not personal," I say, trying to regain my last fucking nerve.

"That's where you're wrong, Miss Graves. It's very fucking personal," he growls.

The tension in my lower stomach snaps, and I turn on him. "Where do you get off coming into my place of business and telling me what I can and cannot do?" I glare at

him, grinding my jaw so I'm not as tempted to bring that fucking scalpel to his throat. "Who the hell do you think you are?"

He steps closer. *Too close*. The overhead lights deepen the shadows on his high cheekbones as he looks down on me, and my hand slides across to the scalpel, enjoying its cool touch. If he notices, he acts indifferent as he towers over me.

"Your worst fucking nightmare if you ever do anything like this again."

The menace in his voice makes me pause. But slowly, the smile tugs at my lips. And it's something he doesn't take too kindly to.

"You find what I say amusing?" he asks.

If looks could kill, I'd be lying in a bloody pool on the morgue floor.

But I've looked the real devil in the face, and he doesn't have impressive cheekbones and a sexy pair of full lips like this guy.

"If you're here to intimidate me, it's not going to work, Mr. Vescari. I dissect bodies for a living. For the most part, they're dead, but sometimes if someone really pisses me off, I'm happy to do so while their blood is still pumping hot," I say, making a point to toy with the scalpel.

Icy tension ripples between us as he stares down at me. "Is that a fact?"

I hate admitting it. But up close, this guy is something else. Narissa, my ride or die, would call him hot AF.

The kind of hot AF who knows how to put his name on your lips when his head is buried between your thighs.

A heated warmth spreads between my legs as his gaze promises damnation.

*Jesus, I need to get laid.*

"It's time for you to leave. I need to get some sleep before I start back tomorrow." I flip the scalpel in my hand with ease.

His jaw tics, and he seems unfazed by my swift movement with the blade. That, or he doesn't think of me as a threat, which is okay by me. Being underestimated at times can be a woman's power.

"Someone from my office will be in touch regarding picking up your friend. Word of advice, be friendly if you actually want to bury him," I say with an insincere smile, the threat hanging in the air. I grab the end of the table, place my scalpel on it, and get him settled in the cooler, fully aware of the psychopath watching every step I make. I can't help but feel a stab of empathy for him. He's lost someone he cared about, and that hurts. *Some would say it hurts so much you can feel your heart break.*

My advice to him would be to stop caring.

Or at least tighten the circle of those who are worth the heartbreak.

I turn my back on him and reach for my coat hanging on the rack next to the door, praying I don't have to use my knee and a can of pepper spray on this asshole as a form of encouragement. But when I turn back around, he hasn't moved.

"This could end badly for you," he warns.

Our eyes connect and lock. And I will die before I look away. "Is that a threat?"

"No, it's a plausible probability. You swim with sharks, you're eventually going to get bitten."

"Nice analogy."

"Not an analogy either. Just friendly advice."

"We're not friends."

"No, we're not."

He stalks out of the room, but I don't move until I hear the door close behind him.

Letting out a deep puff of breath, I walk to the light switch and flick it off. He's gone, but it still feels like he's watching me.

*Tread carefully, Leonore.*

I should pay heed to the voice in my head.

I've made him mad because I can't keep my smart-ass mouth in check.

And making Silas Vescari mad can be fatal.